

Entada phaseoloides (Fabaceae)

Matchbox Bean

Description Woody vine with compound leaves and clusters of pea-type flowers. Huge, flat brown seed pods, containing black glossy seeds, grow to 5 ft (1.5 m) in length, making them the largest-growing legumes in the world.

Habitat & Cultivation Matchbox bean is native to Australia and tropical regions of Asia and Africa. The seeds are collected when the pods are ripe.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents Matchbox bean contains significant amounts of saponins.

History & Folklore The young leaves and roasted bean are eaten as vegetables, whereas fiber from the stems is made into nets, ropes, and sails. Due to the plant's high saponin content, it is used as a shampoo.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Australian Aborigines use the seeds to treat female sterility and indigestion, and as a painkiller. In the Philippines, juice made from the bark is used to treat conjunctivitis.

Equisetum arvense (Equisetaceae)

Horsetail,

Bottlebrush

Description Perennial plant with a yellowish fruiting stem growing to 14 in (35 cm), followed by a sterile segmented and toothed stem growing to 2 ft (60 cm). The latter has whorls of needle-shaped leaves.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, North Africa, northern Asia, and the Americas, horsetail is a common plant, preferring damp soil. The sterile stems are harvested in summer and carefully dried, all discolored parts being discarded.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Horsetail contains large amounts of silicic acid and silicates (about 15%), flavonoids, phenolic acids, alkaloids (including nicotine), and sterols. Much of the therapeutic effectiveness of this herb is due to its high silica content, a large proportion of which is soluble and can be absorbed. Silica supports the regeneration of connective tissue.

History & Folklore Horsetail is a primitive plant that is descended from huge trees that lived during the Palaeozoic era (600–375 million years ago). The herb's high silica content makes it abrasive, and in the past it was used to polish metal and wood. Its common name, bottlebrush, indicates another of its uses. Horsetail was also

tied to the tails of livestock to help them ward off flies. It was long considered a wound-healing herb. The English herbalist John Gerard, writing in 1597, recounted: "Dioscorides saith, that the horse-tail being stamped and laid to, doth perfectly cure wounds, yea although the sinues be cut in sunder, as Galen addeth."

Medicinal Actions & Uses As its traditional usage indicates, horsetail is an excellent clotting agent. It staunches wounds, stops nosebleeds, and reduces the coughing up of blood. In addition, horsetail has an astringent effect on the genitourinary system, proving especially valuable where there is bleeding within the urinary tract, and in cases of cystitis, urethritis, and prostate disease. Horsetail helps to speed the repair of damaged connective tissue, improving its strength and elasticity. The herb is also prescribed to treat problems related to rheumatic and arthritic problems, for chest ailments (such as emphysema), for chronic swelling of the legs, and for various other conditions. A decoction of the herb's aerial parts added to a bath benefits slow-healing sprains and fractures, as well as certain irritable skin conditions such as eczema.

Dried aerial parts



Horsetail staunches bleeding, and is astringent and diuretic.

Cautions Horsetail breaks down vitamin B₁ (thiamine) and should generally be taken long term only in tandem with a B vitamin supplement.

Eriodictyon californicum

(Hydrophyllaceae)

Yerba Santa

Description Sticky evergreen shrub growing to 8 ft (2.5 m). Its narrow lance-shaped leaves are shiny green on the upper side and hairy white underneath. Trumpet-shaped white or blue flowers grow in clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to California and Oregon in the U.S., and northern Mexico, yerba santa flourishes on dry mountain slopes. It grows at altitudes of up to 3,900 ft (1,200 m).

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Yerba santa contains a volatile oil, flavonoids (including eriodictyol), and resin.

History & Folklore The name *yerba santa* (holy weed) was given to this plant by Spanish colonists who learned of its medicinal virtues from Native Americans. Traditionally, the leaves were infused and taken for coughs, colds, sore throats, mucus, and asthma. The infusion was also used as a wash to ease fever, and the mashed leaves were applied as a poultice to treat sores.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An aromatic herb with a pleasant sweet taste, yerba santa is a valuable expectorant that can be used to treat tracheitis, bronchitis, and asthma, and similar respiratory tract ailments.

Ervatamia coronaria (Apocynaceae)

Grape Jasmine,

East Indian Rosebay

Description Perennial shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has dark green, elliptical leaves and strongly perfumed white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Grape jasmine is grown in India, Malaysia, and Indonesia.

Parts Used Root, leaves, latex.

Constituents Grape jasmine contains alkaloids and resins.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Ayurvedic medicine, the root and the latex are used to expel worms. The root is also chewed to relieve toothache. The latex is used to treat cataracts (especially in the early stages), eye inflammations, and poor eyesight. The leaf juice makes a soothing treatment for skin irritations and wounds.

⚠ **Caution** Use grape jasmine only under professional supervision.